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Credit - Drishti Ias

US Midterm Elections 2026: Implications for India

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For Prelims: India-US Relations , H-1B visas , Quad , Initiative on Critical and Emerging Technologies

For Mains: Comparison of Indian and US Constitutional Schemes , Presidential vs Parliamentary Systems of Government

Source: TH

Why in News?

In the recently concluded November 2026 US midterm elections, the Democratic Party secured control of both chambers of the **US Congress** . This sweeping shift in Washington's political landscape introduces strong legislative checks on the **Executive branch and carries significant strategic, economic, and diplomatic implications for India.**

Summary

- US Midterm Elections 2026 highlight the importance of legislative checks and balances and carry implications for India-US trade, immigration, strategic cooperation and investment.
- India can strengthen parliamentary accountability through an independent Parliamentary Budget Office, stronger legislative committees and reforms to the Tenth Schedule to balance political stability with legislative independence.

What are the US Midterm Elections?

- **About:** The United States midterm elections are general elections held near the midpoint of a president's four-year term in office.
  - They take place on the Tuesday following the first Monday in November of even-numbered years that do not feature a presidential election (e.g., 2018, 2022, 2026).

- **The US Congress** : The national legislature is collectively known as the **US Congress (comprising both the House and the Senate).**
  - The US follows a **de facto two-party system** , dominated by the **Republican and Democratic Parties** across all three levels of government.
- **House of Representatives (Similar to India's Lok Sabha):** This is the lower house of Congress. All 435 voting seats are up for election during midterms.
  - Representatives serve two-year terms, meaning their entire tenure is tied to either a **presidential or a midterm election cycle.**
  - Just like the Lok Sabha, its members are **directly elected by the public** to represent specific population-based constituencies (districts).
- **The Senate (Similar to India's Rajya Sabha):** This is the upper house of Congress. Roughly one-third of the 100 Senate seats are contested.
  - Senators serve **staggered six-year terms** , so they do not all face election at the same time. Similar to the Rajya Sabha, it acts as a **continuing chamber representing the states.**
  - However, unlike India's Rajya Sabha (where seats depend on population), every **US state gets exactly two Senators** , and they are directly elected by the voters of that state.
- **Special Powers of Congress:**
  - **House of Representatives:** Has the exclusive power to initiate revenue-raising bills and impeach federal officials.
  - **Senate:** Confirms major presidential appointments, provides consent to treaties and conducts impeachment trials.
  - **Presidential Veto:** The President may **veto legislation passed by Congress** , but both chambers can **override the veto with a two-thirds majority.**
    - Conviction in an impeachment trial also requires a two-thirds majority of senators present.
- **Political Significance of Midterm Elections:**
  - **The Referendum Effect:** Midterms are widely viewed as a national scorecard on the sitting president’s performance and the ruling party's policies.
  - **Divided Government:** If the opposition party wins control of either the House or the Senate during a midterm, it creates a **"divided government."**
    - This severely limits the president's ability to pass domestic legislation, as the **opposition can block bills,** control the federal budget, and launch congressional investigations into the executive branch.



Impact on India-US Relations

- **Trade and Economic Ties:**
  - **Tariffs:** The Trump administration's tendency to use aggressive tariffs as a foreign policy tool may face pushback from a Democrat-controlled Congress concerned about **inflation and supply chain disruptions.** This could lead to a more predictable trade environment for Indian exports.
  - **Non-Tariff Barriers:** Conversely, Democrats historically place a stronger emphasis on **labor rights, human rights, and environmental standards,** which could introduce new compliance pressures on Indian businesses and trade negotiations.
  - **Limits of Congressional Oversight:** Although a Democrat-controlled Congress may intensify scrutiny of tariffs, the President retains delegated trade powers under **Section 232 of the Trade Expansion Act, 1962, and Section 301 of the Trade Act, 1974.**
    - Consequently, greater legislative oversight may not necessarily result in immediate tariff reductions for Indian exports.
- **Immigration and H-1B Visas:** Democrats generally advocate for a more predictable and less restrictive approach to skilled legal immigration.
  - Congressional oversight might curb drastic executive actions that target **H-1B visas,** providing relief to Indian IT professionals and the tech sector.
- **Geopolitical Alignments and the Indo-Pacific:** Bipartisan support for India's strategic role in the **Indo-Pacific** provides continuity to cooperation through the **Quad,** defence partnerships and the **TRUST (Transforming the Relationship Utilizing Strategic Technology) initiative, launched in 2025** to advance collaboration in AI, semiconductors, quantum technologies and other critical sectors.
- **Foreign Institutional Investment (FII):** A divided US government and domestic policy gridlock can **redirect global capital, making high-growth emerging markets like India more attractive and driving a rise in FII inflows** into the Indian stock market.

US Congress vs. Indian Parliament

Dimension	US Congress	Indian Parliament
System of Governance	**Presidential Republic:** Strict constitutional separation of powers between executive and legislative branches.	**Parliamentary Republic:** Fusion of powers. The Union executive emerges from and remains answerable to the legislature.
Executive Mandate & Stability	The **President serves a fixed 4-year term** and remains in office even if the opposition wins both chambers of Congress.	The **Prime Minister and the Council of Ministers** must command a continuous majority in the Lok Sabha. Losing this majority necessitates the resignation of the government, irrespective of its numerical strength in the Rajya Sabha.
Lower House Midterm	**100% of seats contested** : All 435 House Representatives face direct	**100% contested only if premature: All 543 Lok Sabha MPs** face simultaneous direct elections if the House is dissolved early

Elections	re-election every two years.	(Madhyavadhi Chunav). Normal tenure is five years.
Upper House Turnover & Rotation in Midterm	Approximately **1/3 retire or contest re-election** : Senators serve six-year terms divided into three staggered classes. **Around 33–34 Senate seats expire at each midterm.**	1/3 retire biennially: Under Article 83(1), the **Rajya Sabha is a permanent body** and cannot be dissolved. One-third of its members retire every second year, independently of Lok Sabha elections.
Upper House Electorate	Direct popular election across entire states. Every state is allocated exactly 2 seats (equal representation), regardless of its population size.	Indirect election by elected members of **State Legislative Assemblies (MLAs)** through proportional representation by single transferable vote, plus 12 nominated members. Indian states do not have an equal number of seats; seats are allocated based on the state's population.
Party Discipline	Flexible / Weak: No anti-defection law. Lawmakers can cross party lines to vote according to conscience or constituency interests.	Rigid / Mandatory: The **Tenth Schedule (Anti-Defection Law)** regulates voting against party directions. Violations can result in disqualification.
Budgetary Power	Power of the Purse: Congress has substantial control over the budget and can extensively rewrite executive proposals.	The executive drafts and dominates the budget. **Money Bills** require a simple majority in the Lok Sabha, often with limited debate and guillotine closures.

What Lessons Can India Learn from the US for Indian Parliamentary Reform?

- **Independent Parliamentary Budget Office (PBO):** Congress relies on the **non-partisan Congressional Budget Office (CBO)** to evaluate fiscal impacts.
  - Establishing an independent PBO within the Lok Sabha Secretariat would provide MPs with non-partisan fiscal modelling, **restoring substantive parliamentary oversight** over the Ministry of Finance and reducing reliance on "guillotined" budget demands.
- **Re-Energizing Departmental Committees:** Congressional committees hold open, televised evidentiary hearings with expert witnesses. India should **introduce a mandatory rule requiring major substantive bills to undergo scrutiny by Departmentally Related Standing Committees (DRSCs)** , allowing open hearings with outside technical experts and public stakeholder testimony to build cross-party consensus.
- **Rationalizing the Anti-Defection Law:** US lawmakers operate with genuine legislative agency. Following recommendations from the **Law Commission of India (170th Report)** , India could narrow

the scope of disqualification whips strictly to **No-Confidence Motions , Confidence Motions, and Money Bills.** On standard legislative bills, MPs should be free to vote according to constituency interests.

Conclusion

The US system prioritises institutional checks and executive oversight, while India emphasises executive stability and efficiency. India can strengthen parliamentary accountability through independent budgetary oversight, stronger committees and selective anti-defection reforms without compromising government stability.

Drishti Mains Question:

The US presidential system institutionalises separation of powers, whereas India's parliamentary system emphasises executive accountability to the legislature. Compare the two systems and examine their respective strengths and limitations.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What are US midterm elections and when are they held?
They are elections held every four years at the midpoint of the US President's four-year term, with all 435 House seats and approximately one-third of Senate seats contested.

2. What is a divided government in the United States?
It occurs when the President's party does not control both chambers of Congress, potentially restricting legislative approvals and strengthening congressional oversight of the Executive.

3. What is the Congressional Budget Office (CBO)?
The CBO is a non-partisan agency of the US Congress that provides independent economic forecasts, budgetary estimates and fiscal analysis to support legislative decision-making.

4. What is the significance of the Tenth Schedule of the Indian Constitution?
Introduced through the 52nd Constitutional Amendment Act, 1985, it provides for the disqualification of legislators on grounds of defection, subject to specified exceptions.

5. What reforms can India adopt from the US Congress to strengthen parliamentary accountability?
India can establish an independent Parliamentary Budget Office, strengthen committee scrutiny through public hearings and rationalise the Anti-Defection Law to improve legislative independence.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ **https://www.youtube.com/embed/0ABMR-zFS1k**]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Mains

Q. Examine how the separation of powers is practised in India compared to the rigid presidential model of the United States of America. In this context, compare the actual authority of the Indian Prime Minister with that of the President of the USA. **(2026)**

Q. Compare and contrast the President’s power to pardon in India and in the USA. Are there any limits to it in both the countries? What are ‘preemptive pardons’? **(2025)**

Q. Discuss India as a secular state and compare with the secular principles of the US constitution. **(2024)**

Death Penalty: Supreme Court's Evolving Jurisprudence

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For Prelims: Death Penalty , Mercy Petition , Article 72 , Article 161 , Curative Petition , ICCPR

For Mains: Death penalty jurisprudence in India and the “Rarest of Rare” doctrine, Judicial safeguards and procedural fairness in capital sentencing.

Source: TH

Why in News?

World Day Against the Death Penalty has renewed debate over India’s **capital punishment framework** , particularly the implementation of the **‘Rarest of Rare’ doctrine (1980)** and the Supreme Court’s recent emphasis on fairness, due process and constitutional safeguards during death penalty sentencing.

Summary

- World Day Against the Death Penalty highlights the need to ensure that India's 'Rarest of Rare' doctrine is implemented effectively, with fairness and constitutional safeguards in capital punishment cases.
- Despite Supreme Court guidelines, rushed sentencing, flawed investigations and inadequate consideration of reformation risk wrongful executions, highlighting the need for stronger judicial safeguards and human rights protection.

What is the Death Penalty in India?

- **About:** The death penalty, or capital punishment, is the **highest degree of punishment awarded** under the Indian penal system for the most heinous crimes.
  - Under the Indian criminal justice system, life imprisonment is the rule, and the death penalty is the exception.
- **Historical & Philosophical Roots:** Rooted in the concept of retributive justice (proportionate punishment for severe crimes), it finds historical mention in the Manusmriti and was formally codified under the erstwhile **Indian Penal Code (1860).**
- **Statutory Framework:** Section 354(3) of the Code of Criminal Procedure (CrPC), 1973, now Section 393(3) of the **Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), 2023,** mandates that **judges must record "special reasons" for awarding a death sentence.**
  - The **Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), 2023** retains capital punishment and notably expands it to include offences such as **mob lynching** **(if it results in death) and the rape of a minor.** Overall, around 14 grave offences, including murder, terrorism, and abetment of mutiny, attract this punishment.
- **The 'Rarest of Rare' Doctrine:** In the landmark ***Bachan Singh v. State of Punjab (1980)*** **case** , a Constitution Bench of the Supreme Court upheld the validity of the death penalty but limited judicial discretion.
  - It established the **"rarest of rare" doctrine,** dictating that a death sentence can only be imposed when the alternative of life imprisonment is "unquestionably foreclosed."
- **Balancing Crime and Criminal:** The doctrine requires courts to weigh the aggravating circumstances (the brutality of the crime) against the mitigating circumstances (the social, psychological, and economic background of the criminal).
- **Statutory Exemptions:** The Indian legal system provides strict humanitarian exemptions; **juveniles (under 18 at the time of the offence), pregnant women, and persons with mental illness** cannot be subjected to execution.
- **Mandatory Appellate Process:** A death sentence handed down by a **Sessions Court is not immediately final** ; it must be **mandatorily confirmed by the High Court** before it can be executed, and the convict retains the right to appeal to the **Supreme Court** .
- **Constitutional Clemency:** Death row convicts can file a **Mercy Petition** seeking pardon, reprieve, or commutation from the **President of India** under **Article 72** or the **Governor under Article 161** of the Constitution.
- **Final Judicial Remedy:** Even after the rejection of a review petition, convicts have the right to file a

Curative Petition, a final legal remedy recognized in the landmark **Rupa Ashok Hurra v. Ashok Hurra (2002)** judgment to prevent gross miscarriages of justice.

Evolution of Due Process in Capital Sentencing

- **The Crime-Centric Era (1983–1995):** Despite *Bachan Singh* , subsequent judgments severely diluted the focus on the individual, leading to a precarious, crime-centric jurisprudence.
  - ***Machhi Singh v. State of Punjab (1983):*** This ruling shifted the inquiry away from the criminal and heavily toward the circumstances of the crime.
  - ***Ravji v. State of Rajasthan (1995):*** A two-judge Bench erroneously held that the nature and gravity of the offense, not the circumstances of the criminal, were what mattered most in deciding the punishment.
    - Relying on this flawed legal principle, two men were executed in 1996 and 1997. Fourteen retired judges later termed these executions "the gravest known miscarriage of justice" in independent India.
- **Restoring Reformation (2009):** In ***Santosh Kumar Bariyar v. State of Maharashtra (2009)*** , the Supreme Court recognized the historical error.
  - The Court declared the *Ravji* judgment ***per incuriam*** **(decided in ignorance of binding law)** because it completely ignored the *Bachan Singh* guidelines.
  - The Court clarified that life imprisonment is only "unquestionably foreclosed" when the **State can prove that the sentencing aim of reformation is unachievable.**
- **Institutionalizing Mitigation** : Recognizing that trial courts were still sentencing **people to death without investigating their backgrounds,** the Supreme Court stepped in to formalize the collection of mitigating evidence.
  - ***Manoj v. State of Madhya Pradesh (2022):*** Mandated psychological, psychiatric, prison conduct and socio-economic background reports before imposing the death penalty.
- **Elevating Due Process to a Constitutional Right (2025–2026):** The Supreme Court has transformed the sentencing procedure from a mere statutory guideline into an enforceable fundamental right.
  - ***Vasanta Sampat Dupare v. Union of India (2025):*** The Court declared that a rigorous, individualized sentencing hearing strictly compliant with the *Manoj* guidelines flows directly from Article 14 (Equality before the law) and Article 21 (Right to life) of the Constitution.
    - A death sentence imposed without this rigorous hearing is **unconstitutional and can be reopened even after the appeals process has ended.**
  - ***Waris v. State of Madhya Pradesh (2026):*** While upholding a conviction for the brutal rape and murder of a child, the Supreme Court commuted the death sentence because the **State failed to present evidence excluding the possibility of the convict's reformation.**
    - The Court reinforced that the extreme gravity of a crime cannot, on its own, establish that life imprisonment is foreclosed.

World Day Against the Death Penalty

- **Origin and Observance:** Launched in **2003 by the World Coalition Against the Death Penalty** (a global civil society network), the day is observed annually on **10th October** to unite civil society, legal professionals, and policymakers in the fight against capital punishment.
- **Thematic Approach:** The initiative highlights a **specific theme every two years** to foster collective global reflection, raise awareness, and provide advocacy tools on distinct aspects of the death penalty.
- **2026 Theme:** The theme for 2026 is **"Stories for Life,"** which shifts the focus away from abstract statistics toward the individual people, families, and communities directly impacted by death row sentences.
- **Core Human Rights Concerns:** The abolitionist movement argues that capital punishment fundamentally violates **human rights and human dignity** .
  - Crucially, it is an **irreversible punishment** that carries a permanent **risk of judicial error (miscarriage of justice)** .
- **Global Status:** At the end of 2025, 145 countries had abolished the death penalty in law or practice (reflecting a strong global trend); thousands of individuals remain on death row, and several retentionist countries continue to carry out executions.

International Human Rights Framework

The abolitionist movement draws its legal and moral authority from several foundational human rights documents:

- **Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR, 1948):** Article 3 guarantees the right to life, liberty, and security, while Article 5 strictly prohibits torture and cruel, inhuman, or degrading punishment.
- **International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights (ICCPR, 1966):** Article 6 protects the inherent right to life.
  - For countries that have not abolished the death penalty, the **ICCPR** restricts its application to only the "most serious crimes". **India is a party to the ICCPR.**
- **Second Optional Protocol to the ICCPR (1989):** This is the only universal international treaty explicitly aimed at the total abolition of the death penalty. **India is not a signatory to this protocol** .

What are the Persistent Challenges in the Current Sentencing System?

- **Trial Court Non-Compliance:** Despite clear apex court rulings, trial courts remain deeply crime-centric.
  - Of the 128 death sentences imposed in 2025, an analysis of 83 cases found that 79 cases (95.18%) failed to comply with the Manoj sentencing safeguards.
  - **Muzaffarnagar Case (2026):** An analysis of nine judgments involving 23 death sentences imposed by a Muzaffarnagar trial judge raised concerns about excessive reliance on the brutality of crimes and

inadequate consideration of mitigating circumstances.

- **Rushed Sentencing Hearings:** A nationwide study of 306 death sentences (2018–2020) revealed that **36.1% were pronounced on the exact same day as the conviction** , and 18.4% the following day, denying the defence any meaningful opportunity to present mitigating evidence.
- **High Acquittal Rates on Appeal:** Nearly one-third of death sentences reviewed by High Courts and the Supreme Court over the past decade have resulted in complete acquittals.
- **Flawed Investigations:** In 2025 alone, the **Supreme Court acquitted the accused in 10 out of 19 death penalty cases** it reviewed, repeatedly citing poorly conducted investigations, opaque confessions, and forensic evidence of "doubtful rigour."
  - A criminal justice system prone to investigatory errors cannot safely impose an irreversible punishment based solely on the public's emotional reaction to a crime.
- **Socio-Economic Bias:** The burden of capital punishment falls disproportionately on marginalized communities. Most death row inmates belong to **economically vulnerable backgrounds** and lack access to competent legal representation during the critical trial phase.

What Measures are Needed to Reform India's Capital Punishment Framework?

- **262nd Law Commission Report (2015):** It recommended the abolition of the death penalty for all crimes except terrorism-related offenses and waging war against the State.
  - This aligns India with **Article 6 of the ICCPR** , which restricts capital punishment exclusively to the "most serious crimes" involving intentional lethal intent.
- **Statutory Mitigation Infrastructure:** India must create a state-funded cadre of **independent Mitigation Specialists** (social workers and psychologists).
  - This operationalizes the **Manoj guidelines** ensuring an accused's socio-economic, structural, and trauma history is investigated independently of the police.
- **Executive Clemency & 'Death Row Syndrome':** The agonizing delay in deciding mercy petitions causes "Death Row Syndrome".
  - India must give statutory backing to the **Shatrughan Chauhan vs Union of India (2014) guidelines** , enforcing transparent, binding timelines for the President and Governors to decide on **Article 72 and 161 Mercy Petitions** .
- **Exemption for Severe Mental Illness:** Aligning with the **UN ECOSOC Safeguards and the UN Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (CRPD) .**
  - The BNSS, 2023, must explicitly prohibit the sentencing or execution of individuals with **severe mental health or intellectual disabilities.**
- **Intermediate Sentencing:** Promote the consistent and principled use of alternatives to the death penalty, including imprisonment for the remainder of the convict's natural life without remission, where legally permissible.
  - In Waris v. State of Madhya Pradesh (2026), the Supreme Court adopted such an intermediate sentence while commuting the death penalty.

Conclusion

The constitutionality of the death penalty depends on procedural fairness, reformation opportunities and Article 21 safeguards, not retributive justice. India must strengthen mitigation frameworks and

ensure sentencing remains guided by constitutional principles rather than public outrage to prevent irreversible miscarriages of justice.

Drishti Mains Question:

Should India move towards the abolition of the death penalty? Examine the arguments for and against abolition in the context of constitutional morality, human dignity and criminal justice reforms.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is the 'Rarest of Rare' doctrine in India?
Established in Bachan Singh v. State of Punjab (1980), it restricts the death penalty to exceptional cases where life imprisonment is unquestionably foreclosed.

2. Which constitutional provisions govern mercy petitions in India?
Article 72 empowers the President, while Article 161 empowers Governors to grant pardon, reprieve, respite or commutation.

3. What are the Manoj guidelines on death penalty sentencing?
In Manoj v. State of Madhya Pradesh (2022), the Supreme Court mandated psychological, psychiatric, prison conduct and socio-economic background reports before death sentencing.

4. What did the 262nd Law Commission Report recommend regarding capital punishment?
The 2015 report recommended abolishing the death penalty for all crimes except terrorism-related offences and waging war against the State.

5. Which international convention specifically seeks the abolition of capital punishment?
The Second Optional Protocol to the ICCPR (1989) aims at the total abolition of the death penalty. India is not a signatory.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/zN44EHgNou0]

UPSC Civil Services Examination Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Mains

Q. Instances of the President's delay in commuting death sentences has come under public debate as denial of justice. Should there be a time limit specified for the President to accept/reject such petitions? Analyse. **(2014)**

Biosphere Reserves in India

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Source: PIB

Why in News?

The **International Day for Biosphere Reserves , observed annually on 3rd November,** highlights the role of these landscapes in biodiversity conservation and sustainable development **.**

What are Biosphere Reserves?

- **About:** Biosphere Reserves are areas designated by **national governments to conserve biodiversity, ecosystems and genetic resources** , while promoting sustainable development and community livelihoods.
- **UNESCO Framework:** Biosphere Reserves are internationally recognised under **UNESCO's Man and the Biosphere (MAB) Programme** , launched in 1971 to improve the relationship between humans and their natural environment.
  - National governments nominate sites for inclusion in **UNESCO's World Network of Biosphere Reserves (WNBR)** .
  - UNESCO-recognised Biosphere Reserves **undergo a periodic review every 10 years to assess their effectiveness** in biodiversity conservation and sustainable development.
  - **National designation and UNESCO recognition are distinct** ; not all nationally designated Biosphere Reserves are included in the WNBR.
- **Living Laboratories:** They serve as sites for testing and demonstrating sustainable resource management, ecological restoration, scientific research and community-based conservation.
- **India's Biodiversity Significance:** India is **one of the world's 17 megadiverse countries, accounting for approximately 7–8% of recorded global species** despite occupying **only 2.4% of Earth's land area.**
- **Distinction from Other Protected Areas:** Unlike National Parks and Wildlife Sanctuaries, which primarily emphasise habitat and wildlife protection, Biosphere Reserves integrate conservation with scientific research, sustainable livelihoods and community participation.
- **Legal Status:** Biosphere Reserve designation does not automatically grant statutory protection to the entire area under the **Wildlife (Protection) Act, 1972** .
  - Core areas may contain legally protected National Parks and Wildlife Sanctuaries, while buffer and transition zones support regulated, conservation-compatible human activities.

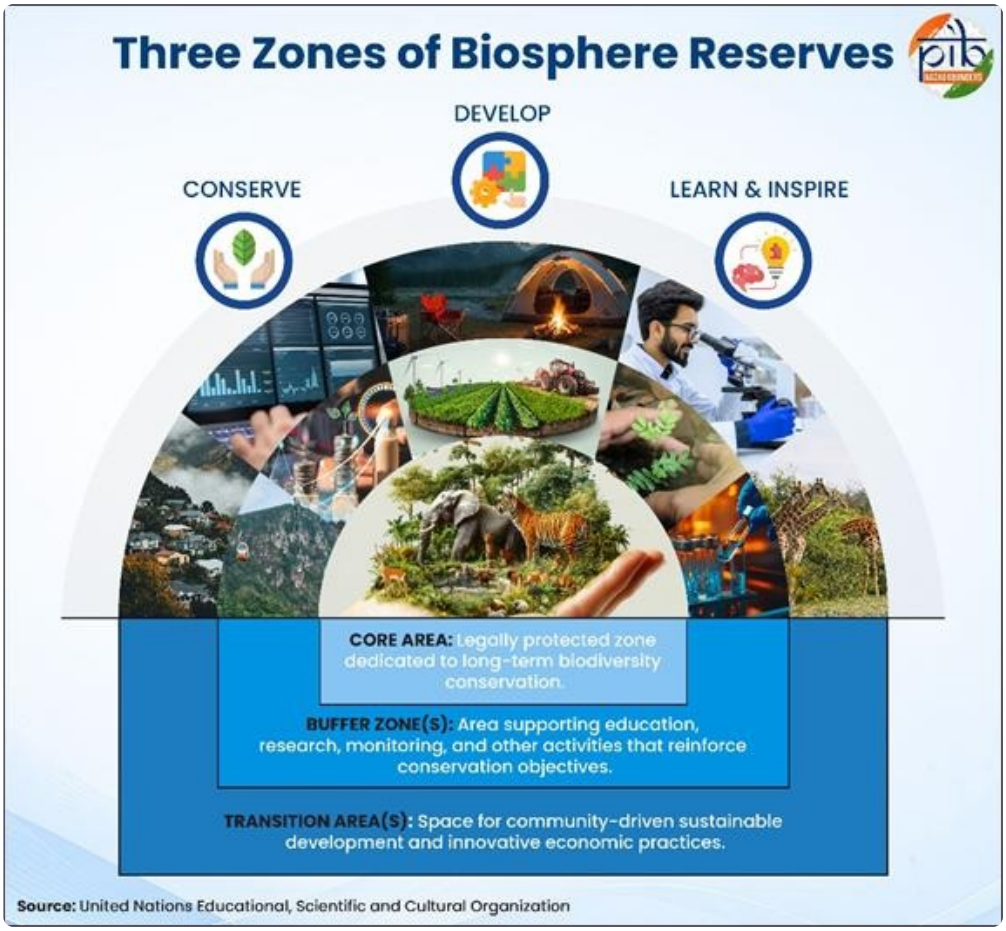
Functions of Biosphere Reserves

- **Conservation:** Protect **ecosystems, landscapes, species, genetic diversity and associated cultural heritage,** maintaining ecological processes and natural habitats.
- **Sustainable Development:** Promote **environmentally sustainable economic activities that support local livelihoods** while respecting ecological limits and cultural traditions.

- **Scientific and Logistical Support:** Facilitate **research, biodiversity monitoring, environmental education, training and knowledge exchange** to strengthen evidence-based conservation.

Three Zones of a Biosphere Reserve

- **Core Zone:** The **most strictly protected area** , conserving natural habitats, biodiversity and ecological processes. Activities are restricted to those compatible with conservation, including approved scientific research and monitoring.
- **Buffer Zone: Surrounds or adjoins the core area and permits environmental education** , research, regulated ecotourism and other conservation-compatible activities.
- **Transition Zone:** The **outer area where communities undertake sustainable agriculture, forestry, tourism and livelihood activities** , demonstrating the integration of conservation and development.
- **Global Distribution:** On average, Biosphere Reserves comprise approximately **18% core, 30% buffer and 52% transition zones** , although these proportions are not mandatory.



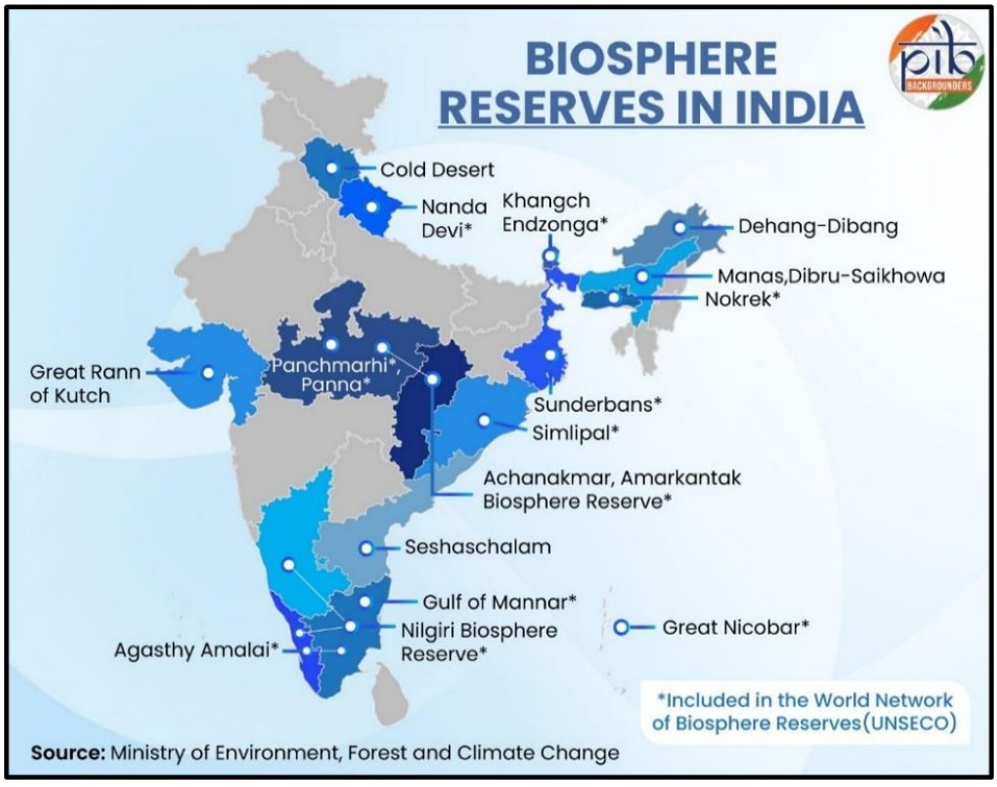
What are the Key Facts About the Global and Indian Biosphere Reserve Networks?

- **Global Significance:** UNESCO's **World Network of Biosphere Reserves (WNBR)** comprises **797 reserves across 145 countries** , benefiting approximately 300 million people.
  - They cover around **5% of Earth's terrestrial surface** while supporting over **60% of global terrestrial vertebrate species richness** .
  - According to the *Map of the World Network of Biosphere Reserves 2025–26* , approximately **40% of reserves may experience more extreme climate events by 2050** , while over 50% overlap with another international conservation designation.

- **India's Biosphere Reserve Network:** India has **18 notified Biosphere Reserves** , of which **13 are included in UNESCO's WNBR** , the highest number among South Asian countries.
  - **First Biosphere Reserve:** **Nilgiri Biosphere Reserve** (1986)
  - **Latest UNESCO Inclusion:** **Cold Desert** became India's 13th UNESCO-recognised Biosphere Reserve in September 2025.

Important Biosphere Reserves in India

- **Nilgiri Biosphere Reserve:** Located in the **Western Ghats** , spanning approximately **5,520 sq. km** across Tamil Nadu, Kerala and Karnataka.
  - Encompasses tropical evergreen forests, montane shola forests and grasslands.
  - Supports endangered species such as the **lion-tailed macaque and Nilgiri tahr** , alongside elephants, tigers and over 550 bird species.
- **Cold Desert Biosphere Reserve:** Located in **Himachal Pradesh** , covering approximately **7,770 sq. km** at elevations of 3,300–6,600 metres.
  - Supports **732 vascular plant species** , including 30 endemic species, along with snow leopards, Himalayan ibex and blue sheep.
  - Local communities practise traditional pastoralism, livestock herding, agriculture and herbal medicine.
- **Gulf of Mannar Biosphere Reserve:** Located off the **southeastern coast of Tamil Nadu** , spanning approximately **10,500 sq. km** .
  - Encompasses **coral reefs, seagrass beds and mangroves** , supporting around 4,223 plant and animal species.
  - Sustains coastal livelihoods through fisheries and other marine-resource-dependent activities, benefiting communities in the surrounding coastal region.



What are the Government Initiatives for Conservation of Biosphere Reserves?

- **Biodiversity Conservation Scheme:** The **Biosphere Reserve Division of MoEFCC** administers the Centrally Sponsored **Biodiversity Conservation Scheme** under the umbrella scheme **Conservation of Natural Resources and Ecosystems** .
- **Financial Support:** The scheme provides **grants-in-aid to States** for conservation and development activities specified in the Management Plans of Biosphere Reserves designated under UNESCO's **Man and the Biosphere (MAB) Programme** .
- **Cost-Sharing Pattern:** Financial assistance is provided on a **60:40 Centre–State basis** for other States and **90:10** for **North-Eastern and Himalayan States** .
- **Implementation:** The scheme is implemented by the respective **State Forest Departments** , with activities guided by approved Management Plans.
- **Integrated Management Plans:** Since **2022–23** , five-year Integrated Management Plans have been piloted for **Nanda Devi, Pachmarhi, Dehang-Dibang and Agasthyamalai** Biosphere Reserves.
- **Key Priorities:** These plans bring together **reserve authorities, research institutions and local communities** , focusing on **habitat restoration, biodiversity monitoring, scientific research and sustainable livelihoods** .

Community-Based Conservation

- **Lantana-Based Livelihoods:** Indigenous communities in the **Nilgiri Biosphere Reserve** convert uprooted *Lantana camara* , an invasive shrub, into elephant sculptures, furniture and handicrafts.
  - **Significance:** Promotes invasive species management, sustainable livelihoods and awareness of human–wildlife coexistence.
  - **Global Recognition:** In 2021, **125 life-sized Lantana elephants were displayed in London** , with sculptures also showcased at Bengaluru Airport and Rashtrapati Bhavan.
- **Lantana camara:** An invasive shrub that has spread across approximately **3 lakh sq. km of Indian forests** , threatening native biodiversity through dense growth, allelopathy (chemical suppression of other plants) and altered fire patterns.

Conclusion

Biosphere Reserves demonstrate how **biodiversity conservation and sustainable development can coexist** . Strengthening community participation, ecological restoration, scientific monitoring and climate-resilient management is essential for protecting India's natural heritage while ensuring sustainable livelihoods.

Drishti Mains Practice Question

Biosphere Reserves provide an integrated framework for reconciling biodiversity conservation with sustainable development. Discuss.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

Q1. When is the International Day for Biosphere Reserves observed?
It is observed annually on 3 November to promote awareness of biodiversity conservation and sustainable development.

Q2. How many Biosphere Reserves are there in India?
As of November 2026, India has 18 notified Biosphere Reserves, of which 13 are recognised under UNESCO's World Network of Biosphere Reserves.

Q3. Which was India's first Biosphere Reserve?
The Nilgiri Biosphere Reserve, established in 1986 across Tamil Nadu, Kerala and Karnataka.

Q4. Which is the latest Indian Biosphere Reserve included in UNESCO's World Network?
The Cold Desert Biosphere Reserve in Himachal Pradesh, included in September 2025.

Q5. What are the three zones of a Biosphere Reserve?
The three zones are the Core Zone for strict conservation, Buffer Zone for conservation-compatible activities and Transition Zone for sustainable livelihoods and economic activities.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/Y_K0N-C3CJI]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Question

Prelims

Q. Consider the following statements:

1. Under the Ramsar Convention, it is mandatory on the part of the Government of India to protect and conserve all the wetlands in the territory of India.
2. The Wetlands (Conservation and Management) Rules, 2010 were framed by the Government of India based on the recommendations of the Ramsar Convention.
3. The Wetlands (Conservation and Management) Rules, 2010 also encompass the drainage area or catchment regions of the wetlands as determined by the authority.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 and 2 only

(b) 2 and 3 only

(c) 3 only

(d) 1, 2 and 3

Ans: (c)

Q. The most important strategy for the conservation of biodiversity together with traditional human life is the establishment of (2014)

(a) biosphere reserves

(b) botanical gardens

(c) national parks

(d) wildlife sanctuaries

Ans: (a)

Q. Out of all the Biosphere Reserves in India, four have been recognized on the World Network by UNESCO. Which one of the following is not one of them? (2008)

(a) Gulf of Mannar

(b) Kanchenjunga

(c) Nanda Devi

(d) Sunderbans

Ans: (b)

Mains

Q. How does biodiversity vary in India? How is the Biological Diversity Act, 2002 helpful in conservation of flora and fauna? **(2018)**

All India Conference of Chairpersons and Members of Public Accounts Committees

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Source: PIB

Why in News?

The **Lok Sabha Speaker** inaugurated the two-day **All India Conference of Chairpersons and Members of Public Accounts Committees (PACs) of Parliament and State/UT Legislatures in Thiruvananthapuram, Keralam.**

- The central theme of the 2026 conference was **“Audit, Accountability and Good Governance: The Evolving Role of PAC”.**

What are the Key Highlights of the PAC Conference?

- **Outcome-Driven Scrutiny:** The Speaker emphasized that the PAC's responsibility extends beyond merely scrutinizing accounts and findings of the **Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG).**
  - Legislative committees must assess whether **public expenditure has translated into tangible development for citizens on the ground.**
- **Fiscal Discipline as a Democratic Pillar:** Fiscal discipline was termed a non-negotiable cornerstone of a healthy democracy.
  - **Every rupee drawn from the public exchequer must be strictly accounted** for and fully utilized for the specific purpose for which it was sanctioned.
- **Digital Integration:** A call was made to establish a **common digital audit monitoring platform for all State Legislatures,** modelled on the lines of the Indian Parliament, to ensure timely audits and track corrective actions efficiently.
- **Keralam Resolution (2026):** The conference called for greater cooperation among PACs, standardised timelines for Action Taken Notes and capacity-building initiatives to strengthen legislative financial oversight.

What are the Key Facts About the Public Accounts Committee?

- **About:** The PAC is a Parliamentary Financial Committee responsible for examining public expenditure and ensuring the Executive's financial accountability to the Legislature.
  - It is one of the three Financial Parliamentary Committees, alongside the Estimates Committee and the Committee on Public Undertakings (CoPU).
  - It is not a constitutional or statutory body. It is constituted annually under Rule 308 of the Rules of Procedure and Conduct of Business in Lok Sabha.

- **Articles 105 (Parliamentary Privileges) and 118 (Rules of Procedure)** provide the broader constitutional framework for parliamentary committees.

- **Historical Genesis:** The PAC was first established in **1921 in the wake of the Montague-Chelmsford Reforms** .
  - Initially, the **Finance Member of the Executive Council (and later the Finance Minister) acted as the Chairman** , which naturally restricted the free expression of views and criticism against the Executive.
- **Post-Republic Shift:** Following the adoption of the Constitution in **1950** , the PAC became a full-fledged **Parliamentary Committee** under the **control of the Speaker** , and the **Minister of Finance was explicitly barred from membership** .
- **Membership Strength:** The PAC consists of a maximum of 22 members, comprising 15 members elected by the Lok Sabha and 7 members elected by the Rajya Sabha (Rajya Sabha members were integrated in 1954-55).
- **Method of Election:** Members are elected annually based on the principle of **proportional representation by means of a single transferable vote** .
- **Ministerial Bar:** A **Minister cannot be elected as a member** . If a sitting member is appointed as a Minister, they automatically cease to be on the Committee.
- **Opposition Leadership:** Until 1966-67, a senior ruling party member headed the committee.
  - However, since **1967** , the Chairperson is appointed by the Lok Sabha Speaker. This is a parliamentary convention, not a constitutional requirement.
- **Tenure:** The term of office for committee members **does not exceed one year** .
- **Primary Functions and Scope:**
  - **Core Mandate:** It primarily examines the **Appropriation Accounts** (expenditure) and the **Annual Finance Accounts** (receipts) of the Government of India.
    - The PAC extensively examines the **Reports of the CAG** . The CAG is widely regarded as the **"friend, philosopher, and guide" of the Committee** .
  - **Scrutiny Checks:** It ensures that disbursed funds were **legally available, applied to the intended purpose, conformed to governing authority** , and that re-appropriations followed the rules.
  - **Autonomous Bodies:** The PAC also examines the income and expenditure statements of **state corporations, trading and manufacturing schemes, and autonomous/semi-autonomous bodies** audited by the CAG.
  - **Qualitative Scrutiny:** The Committee's examination extends beyond the formality of expenditure to assess its **"wisdom, faithfulness, and economy"** .
    - It actively pulls up the government on cases involving **losses, nugatory expenditure, and financial irregularities** .
  - **Excess Grants and Savings:** It examines expenditure that exceeds granted amounts, which must then be regularized by Parliament under **Article 115 of the Constitution** .
    - The PAC also heavily criticizes **"safe" estimating (savings)** , viewing it as a catalyst for waste and extravagance.
  - **Suo Motu Examination:** The PAC may select subjects for detailed examination independently of CAG audit paragraphs, in accordance with Rule 276 of the Lok Sabha Rules.
- **Action Taken Accountability:** The government must furnish replies on PAC recommendations **within six months** to form an **Action Taken Report** . Furthermore, Action Taken Notes on all C&AG paragraphs must be submitted within **4 months via the online Audit Para Monitoring System (APMS) Portal** to achieve zero pendency.

- **Limitations:** The PAC has limited powers as it conducts **only post-expenditure audits.** Its recommendations are non-binding, with no authority over government policy or executive decisions.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. When was the Public Accounts Committee established in India?
The PAC was established in 1921 following the Montague-Chelmsford Reforms. It became a full-fledged parliamentary committee after the adoption of the Constitution in 1950.

2. What is the composition of the Public Accounts Committee?
It consists of 22 members, comprising 15 from the Lok Sabha and 7 from the Rajya Sabha, elected annually through proportional representation by means of a single transferable vote.

3. Who appoints the Chairman of the PAC?
The Lok Sabha Speaker appoints the Chairman. By convention since 1967, the Chairman is selected from the Opposition.

4. What is the role of the CAG in the functioning of the PAC?
The CAG examines government accounts and submits audit reports to Parliament, which are scrutinised by the PAC to identify financial irregularities and ensure proper utilisation of public funds.

5. What is the constitutional significance of Article 115 in relation to the PAC?
Article 115 provides for supplementary, additional or excess grants. Expenditure exceeding parliamentary grants requires subsequent regularisation through Parliament.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ **https://www.youtube.com/embed/FvgX2FPQZZ8**]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Prelims

Q. With reference to the Parliament of India, which of the following Parliamentary Committees scrutinizes and reports to the House whether the powers to make regulations, rules, sub-rules, by-laws, etc., conferred by the Constitution or delegated by the Parliament are being properly exercised by the Executive within the scope of such delegation? (2018)

(a) Committee on Government Assurances

(b) Committee on Subordinate Legislation

(c) Rules Committee

(d) Business Advisory Committee

Ans: (b)

Q . **Consider the following statements** : **(2013)**

1. The Parliamentary Committee on Public Accounts
2. consists of not more than 25 Members of the Lok Sabha
3. scrutinizes appropriation and finance accounts of the Government
4. examines the report of the Comptroller and Auditor General of India

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 only

(b) 2 and 3 only

(c) 3 only

(d) 1, 2 and 3

Ans: B

2026 Binance Hack

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Source: TH

Binance, the **world's largest cryptocurrency exchange,** suffered a massive cyberattack resulting in the loss of approximately USD 6.3 billion in digital assets. Surpassing the USD 1.5 billion Bybit hack of 2025, this incident is now recorded as the **single largest cryptocurrency heist in history.**

- **Modus Operandi:** The breach was executed via **spear-phishing** . A Binance engineer inadvertently downloaded a malware-laced code repository, compromising their laptop and granting attackers access to Binance's internal systems and "hot wallets" (internet-connected crypto wallets used for quick transactions).
  - **Spear phishing** is a targeted cyberattack where hackers send personalized, fake messages usually via email, text, or social media to trick a specific individual, group, or company into revealing sensitive data, sending money, or downloading malware .
- **Targeted Assets:** The hackers primarily targeted assets on the **Ethereum** , **Bitcoin,** Avalanche, and Polygon blockchains.
  - Binance mitigated the crisis by deploying its **Secure Asset Fund for Users (SAFU)** , an emergency reserve financed by trading fees alongside its own capital to restore 95% of stolen assets.
- **Authorization of Stablecoins:** To address fears of volatile, unbacked cryptos, policymakers should explore the authorization of stablecoins.
  - **"Authorization of Stablecoins"** refers to the **government creating a legal framework t** o officially permit and regulate cryptocurrencies that are pegged 1:1 to stable, real-world assets (like fiat currency or gold).
  - In practice, this means stablecoin issuers would be legally required to maintain transparent, audited reserves matching their token supply, comply with strict **Anti-Money Laundering (AML) laws,** and operate safely within the formal financial system.

Read more: Crypto-Currency Exchange

High-Level Committee on Banking for Viksit Bharat

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Source: PIB

The Government of India has constituted a High-Level Committee on Banking for Viksit Bharat, announced in the Union Budget 2026–27, to review **India's banking sector** and recommend structural, institutional, regulatory and legislative reforms to make it globally competitive, financially inclusive and resilient, in line with the vision of **Viksit Bharat, 2047.**

- **Leadership and Tenure:** The committee is chaired by **Suresh N. Patel (former Central Vigilance Commissioner)** and has a mandate to submit its recommendations within **six months** .
  - **Members:** Shirish Chandra Murmu (RBI Deputy Governor), Padmaja Chunduru (former MD & CEO, Indian Bank) and N. S. Vishwanathan (former RBI Deputy Governor).
  - **Member Secretary:** Joint Secretary (Banking), Department of Financial Services, Ministry of Finance.
- **Terms of Reference of the Committee:**
  - **Regulatory & Legal Reforms:** It will review existing frameworks governing commercial banks, **Regional Rural Banks (RRBs)** , and **Cooperative Banks** to enhance efficiency and the "ease of doing banking".
  - **Capital Assessment & Investment:** Tasked with evaluating the long-term capital requirements for banks, **Development Financial Institutions (DFIs)** , and **Non-Banking Financial Companies (NBFCs)** , alongside addressing the **cost of capital** to boost private sector investment.
  - **Financial Inclusion Overhaul:** A critical mandate is to review the legacy **Priority Sector Lending (PSL) framework** and the **Lead Bank Scheme** to ensure they meet modern goals for data-driven, balanced, and inclusive credit delivery.
  - **Digital Integration & Security:** The committee will draft a roadmap for integrating **Artificial Intelligence (AI) and digital innovations** in banking while establishing robust **safeguards against cyber risks** .
  - **Global Competitiveness:** It aims to assess current prudential norms, adapt **global best practices** for the Indian system, and focus on capacity building to create a future-ready banking workforce.

Read more: **Banking Sector: A Pillar of India's Economic Growth**

Kendriya Grihmantri Dakshata Padak 2026

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Source: PIB

The Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) announced the **Kendriya Grihmantri Dakshata Padak** 2026 for 490 personnel from various States, Union Territories, **Central Armed Police Forces (CAPFs)** and Central Police Organisations (CPOs), recognising professional excellence in policing, intelligence and forensic science.

- **About:** An award instituted by the **Ministry of Home Affairs** to recognise outstanding professional performance, promote high standards and boost the morale of police and security personnel.
  - The medal is announced every year **on 31st October, coinciding with the birth anniversary of Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel ,** observed as **Rashtriya Ekta Diwas (National Unity Day) .**
- **Establishment:** Instituted through an **MHA notification dated 1st February 2024,** by consolidating four existing awards.
- **Eligibility Conditions:** There is **no minimum length-of-service requirement** . Nominees must meet prescribed disciplinary and integrity standards.
- **Award Categories:** It recognises professional excellence in four major fields:
  - **Special Operations:** Exceptional performance in **counterterrorism, border security, counter-Left-Wing Extremism operations, arms control, prevention of narcotics smuggling** and rescue operations.
  - **Investigation:** Outstanding service in criminal investigations, including effective and evidence-based investigative work.
  - **Intelligence** : Exceptional performance and courageous service in intelligence-related operations.
  - **Forensic Science:** Meritorious scientific contributions by serving government scientists to forensic investigation and criminal justice.

Read More: Rashtriya Ekta Diwas 2026

e-Sanjeevani

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Source: TOI

India’s national telemedicine service, **e-Sanjeevani,** has **facilitated over 50 crore consultations since its launch in November 2019** , expanding access to healthcare in remote and underserved regions through digital medical consultations.

- The platform now uses an **AI-powered Clinical Decision Support System** and is integrated with **Emergency Response Support System-112 (ERSS-112)** .
- **About e-Sanjeevani:** Launched by the **Ministry of Health and Family Welfare (MoHFW)** in **2019** , eSanjeevani is India's **free, government-run telemedicine service** that connects patients with doctors through online consultations.
  - **Developed by: Centre for Development of Advanced Computing (C-DAC)** , Mohali, under the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY).
  - **Two Service Models:**
    - **Provider-to-Provider (Hub-and-Spoke Model):** Healthcare workers at Ayushman Arogya Mandirs connect patients with doctors and specialists at higher-level hospitals.
    - **Patient-to-Provider (eSanjeevaniOPD):** Patients can consult doctors directly from home using smartphones or computers.
  - **Significance:** eSanjeevani supports Digital India, **Ayushman Bharat** and the **Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission (ABDM)** by providing affordable and accessible healthcare, particularly to underserved communities.
- **Telemedicine:** Telemedicine is a term that covers the **use of technology to deliver clinical care at a distance.**
  - It ensures that **a person receives healthcare when needed** , especially for those with limited access to care.

Read More : **National Telemedicine Service of India: eSanjeevani**